

before missing the last edition due to a ligament tear in his right elbow, which required surgery and kept him out of action for more than a year.

Annu Rani, the woman National Record (NR) holder, strengthened her bid for a fifth consecutive appearance at the World Championships. Placed 28th in the rankings, the 32-year-old continued her consistent season as no one could challenge her throw of 61.05m for gold. This was her third straight competition in August crossing the 61m mark. "I didn't want to peak today because then nothing would have been left for the World Championships," said Annu.

Touch-and-go

For long jumper Murali Sreeshankar (**right**), the meet in Chennai ended with mixed feelings. The Asian Games silver medallist had been out of action since sustaining a tear in his patellar tendon in April last year, which forced him to miss the Paris Olympics. The 26-year-old from Kerala returned to competition this July and, commendably, competed in five events in six weeks to meet the criterion to enter the World Rankings. Not only that, he won all five while producing a best of 8.13m.

In Chennai, his target was to breach the automatic qualification mark of 8.27m, but he managed only 8.06m. According to the penultimate list, the athlete at the 36th and final qualification spot available through the world rankings had a score of 1195. Sreeshankar will enter the final list with 1196. Will he make it?

"I was trying to chase something which was supposed to be done in the span of a year," said a slightly disappointed Sreeshankar.

"If the World Championships qualification doesn't happen, I definitely need a break to unwind and get ready for the next season, which comprises the Commonwealth Games and the Asian Games."

Tejas Shirse, the National Record holder in the men's 110m hurdles, too, wasn't particularly pleased despite winning gold, as his 13.60s in wet, slippery conditions after a heavy downpour might not earn him enough ranking points to qualify for Tokyo.

Both Sreeshankar and Tejas could also have benefitted from tougher competition, as the second-placed finishers in their respective events jumped only 7.71m and clocked 14.03s.

On target: Annu Rani, the woman National Record holder, won gold in javelin with a throw of 61.05m. PICS: R. RAGU

